Tell no one what you've seen / You'll Never be Alone

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/66966292.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Brief mention of other characters - Freeform, Hurt/Comfort, I took the angst from the comic and ran with it, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Adora has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), No beta we die like the fandom when the comic dropped on May

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-06-28 Words: 2,213 Chapters: 1/1

Tell no one what you've seen / You'll Never be Alone

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/66966292.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Brief mention of other characters - Freeform, Hurt/Comfort, I took the angst from the comic and ran with it, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Adora has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), No beta we die like the fandom when the comic dropped on May

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-06-28 Words: 2,213 Chapters: 1/1

Tell no one what you've seen / You'll Never be Alone

by BlueDandyLyon

Summary

Adora has never been particularly good at communicating her emotions, or wants, or difficulties. Maybe she's just not good at communicating period. But that's fine. Nobody needs to know that nightmares plague her sleep, or that she can't stand to be in a room full of her friends because she might burst into tears. Nobody needs to know that no matter what she does, she still can't be happy. Even after the war is over.

Maybe especially because the war is over.

OR: Adora's pov through the 5th anniversary comic Nate Stevenson released and Catradora's conversation afterwards.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes



Adora clung to the war room's doorway, feet unwilling to move. Now repurposed for general hangouts and activities, nobody called it the war room anymore.

Nobody except for her.

Because as much as she liked to pretend it was over for her, green irises still clung to her closed eyes at night, adrenaline still prepared her for fights that would never come, and the weight of failure still popped its head in uneventful mundanity.

Why was she like this?

Hearing the laughter emanating from the room, her chest clenched as she realized she wouldn't be able to pretend, to smile, to engage in conversation. There was only guilt at not being able to be happy after everything. She even failed at that, how pathetic.

She took a deep breath to distract herself with the cacophony of excited yells. Glimmer was planning a new adventure game. Except it had never been a game for her. Every time she looked at that board, she was reminded of the sleepless nights coming up with strategies to defend perimeters. Those figures forced her to hear the echoes of pained screams in battle. And then she looked at Catra, completely mesmerized by Bow's action figure, and although there was so much love in her heart for the only person who would understand her, she was also hurt; those stupid dice just reminded her of plans to hurt each other, and Catra didn't deserve that.

None of her friends deserved that.

They deserved fun, and peace, and relaxation; things that clearly, Adora was not worthy of. Never had been and never would be. So why would she burden the others with her faults? It'd be better to just leave them be. Her vision darkened as she retreated from the promise of gentleness and into comforting shadows.



She wished Catra would follow her, but it was selfish of her to hope for that. Catra was finally happy. Adora never thought she'd see the day when Catra felt excited about plans with other people, let alone Adora's friends; they were her friends now too. That filled Adora's heart with warmth, but it also made her hyper-aware of the fact that she couldn't provide the same. Catra was probably getting tired of her already: of her inability to be happy, of being unable to exist in a world that did not need her abilities. She was barely aware of her own steps as she left the castle, her mind swirling as Swift Wind felt her distress and offered her a ride. No questions asked for once. She knew she was letting him down too, ignoring his worry. She'd just have to add it to the growing pile of disappointment.



And because she couldn't escape her past, she went to the only place that used to help her, back then. Back when Catra and her talked about ruling the world together. When all they needed to think about was completing the next simulation and climbing the ranks. It was hell, no use romanticizing their upbringing. But there

was a sense of peace in knowing exactly what was expected of Adora that peacetime did not bring.

It looked different now, covered in all the foliage. The beautiful chaos of nature at odds with the industrial precision of the rusted buildings. She could relate to it, somehow. Despite the growth on the surface, her core was built with hard steel, and no amount of seeds would get rid of it.

She thought she could find peace out in the cosmos, then she thought she could find peace in the embrace of her loved ones, and when she couldn't find peace in the mismatched eyes of her partner, that's when she knew there was something fundamentally wrong with her. Something that would never heal. The product of a world designed for conditions that no longer existed. A soldier without a war.

"There will be no future, not for you"

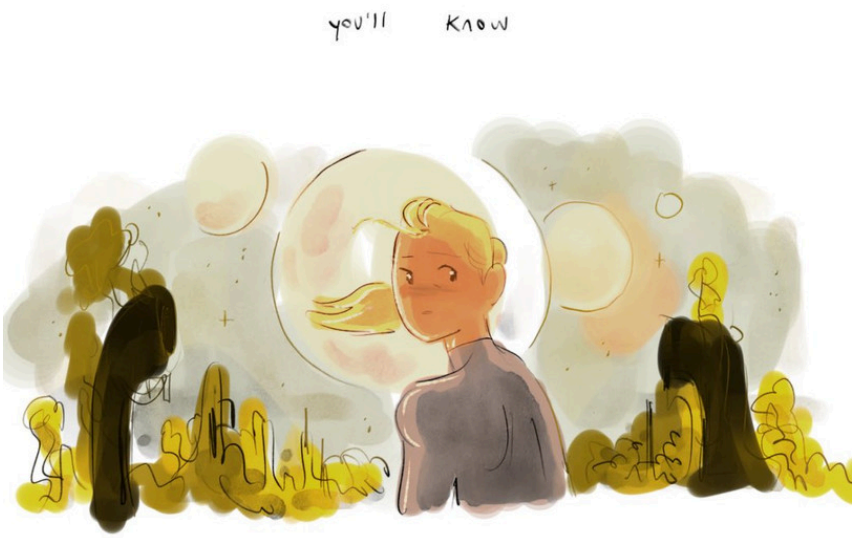
Perhaps Horde Prime had been right, after all. Even with his existence wiped from every dimension, he still found a way to haunt her. Familiar tears burn her cheeks, her body's desperate attempt to fix things, even now when there was nothing to fix.

Distracted by her sobs, she did not hear the signature soft padding of her feet, the way the air subtly changed to account for her presence until Adora heard Catra's small, worried voice. "Adora?"



It was a tone Adora had heard very often recently, one she could originally trace back to that distress call back on Darla's ship. The call that simultaneously introduced hope into her heart before breaking it once more: the call where Catra apologized. Although this time, the only distance threatening them was of Adora's creation, not the other way around; it'd been that way every time Catra had used that tone since.

Adora took a second to wipe her tears, even though it was useless. There was no hiding from Catra. Turning around to face her felt like moving through lead.



Catra's eyes searched her, and whatever she found in them made her gaze soften in empathy; although, it was hard for Adora to feel like it wasn't pity she saw in them instead. Adora forced a smile and turned around, facing the night sky. The relief she felt at Catra having followed her battled with shame at her own outburst.

Catra sat down beside her, moved her tail to rest on Adora's thigh. A question. One that Adora didn't know how to answer. Even if she wanted to be touched, she did not deserve it; so she kept warmth at arm's length.

"Do you… do you want to talk about it?" Catra kept her gaze forward. Adora appreciated the gesture. She did not want to feel like she was under scrutiny on top of everything.

"There isn't anything to talk about." Adora crossed her arms, trying to hide her shame by closing herself off.

"You refused to enter a room full of your friends having fun, so forgive me if I have trouble believing that." Catra chuckled without humor.

Adora's jaw tightened. Her partner was extremely observant, she knew something was up. If she kept pretending nothing was wrong, Catra would get fed up and leave, hurt by Adora's lack of communication. If she admitted to the truth: that she was just fundamentally broken to the point where even when everything was okay, she still felt miserable, Catra would get fed up and leave. Adora wouldn't blame her. Either way she responded, she lost.

A small, naive part of her hoped for reassurance instead, but who would want to be with somebody who suffered in the absence of conflict? Adora hated the envy she felt in her gut at the ease Catra transitioned to a life without war. Adora saw it in the way she stretched in the mornings, leaving languid kisses along Adora's jaw. She heard it when Catra's high-pitched giggles reverberated along the hallways when having tea with Glimmer.

Well, if Catra was going to leave her, she might as well hurry the process along before it killed her later. She sighed. "There isn't anything to talk about.-"

Catra shook her head and withdrew her tail from her thigh, tensing up. Adora missed the faint, comforting heat immediately. "Adora…"

She desperately held up a hand and looked into Catra's eyes, pleading. Catra gave her a terse, defeated look, but nodded at her softly to continue. "There isn't anything to talk about, and that's the worst part. There isn't anything actually wrong, I just…" *I'm the one who's wrong.* She sighed instead. "Do you remember back when we had free block?"

Catra scrunched up her eyebrows with clear suspicion. She had evidently been ready for a fight, but now her body language oozed confusion. The curve-ball made her stammer. "I- I

remember you wasting it making battle plans while I napped." She accused.

Adora heart swelled with affection. Of course Catra would get it, would understand why she was having so much trouble living in a world with no tasks. Why hadn't she spoken to her sooner? She gestured wildly. "Yeah! Exactly!"

Hope vanished from Adora's chest as soon as she saw Catra's expression. She hadn't understood. It was the same look Catra had given her all those years ago when Adora fell off the skiff and told her about the sword. She even light-heartedly said "are you brain damaged?" just like that time. Except this time, half a decade and a war later, it hurt a little more from the probable veracity of it. Though, when Catra apologized after noticing Adora's broken expression, Adora realized just how far they'd both come since then. "I just don't know where you're going with this." Catra's tail landed on Adora's thigh once more. This time, she petted it gently, earning a soft smile from Catra.

Well, Catra was trying to understand. Even if it wasn't the seamless comprehension Adora had briefly hoped for, it was still better than all the scenarios tormenting her head. "I've never been able to relax. Not now, not ever. I spent free block wishing for training to begin again just so I could have something to do." *Which is why I will never be able to do it. How am I supposed to live happily when there is nothing left to do?* Adora fidgeted with her sleeve, her clothes the only remaining constant in her life.

Catra sighed. "Adora, you know it's not the same."

"Isn't it?" Adora's voice broke as it raised. "My friends are all having fun together while I sit here, useless." The only reason she cut herself off before *Honestly, you're better off without me* is due to the pity she would receive. And she didn't want pity, she wanted… she didn't know what she wanted. Because she'd gotten everything she thought she did, and she was still not happy.

"Your friends are worried about you. They noticed you were gone, just like I did. They didn't follow you here because they respect your space, unlike me." Catra's fondness behind her tired smirk made Adora's hand move of her own accord to cup her cheek, which Catra nuzzled gratefully.

"I'm so worried of disappointing everyone, Catra. What if I can't be the friend everyone needs me to be?" Tears sprung to her eyes after finally verbalizing the lump of lead she had been carrying around for months.

Catra's eyebrows raised, clearly unimpressed. "Needs you to be? Now you need to win at friendship too?" Catra snickered and shook her head. "Adora you don't need to *be* anybody, that's the whole point. For the first time in our lives, we can sit on this shitty roof and not think about the people we need to be to survive, isn't that nice?"

Adora's stomach clenched. *No. It's terrifying*. It was scary not knowing what she needed to do to keep people on her side. But she didn't want to make Catra feel misunderstood so she just grumbled, "I… guess" and crossed her arms again.

Catra looked at her intensely. "Hey, there is no one out there who can tell us anything about who we are, or what we're worth. We create our own lives now, and that's awesome."

"Since when are you so wise?" Adora smirked.

Catra shrugged sheepishly, ears drooping shyly. "I've been spending time with Perfuma, is all."

"Have you now?" Adora lightly shoved her shoulder.

"Yeah, turns out she actually knows her shit. You should hang out with her sometime."

"But her meditations are *sooo* boring" Adora groaned.

"If you actually told her that, she would give you different types of meditations. It sure sucks being a people-pleaser like you." Catra pouts mockingly.

"I'm not a people-pleaser!" Adora pouted.

"Oh yeah? Prove it."

Adora opened her mouth in challenge but quickly closed it after no retort came to her. "I don't… know how to do that." She tittered, scratching the back of her head.

Catra plopped down on the steel floor. "Do something you want to do just for the sake of it." Faking indifference, she yawned and closed her eyes. Adora knew she did it to take the pressure off her secretly loaded request.

Adora couldn't help but smile down at her. She smiled at her ears twitching softly, waiting for Adora's move. She smiled at her childhood best friend. The only one who knew the only way Adora would share her woes, was to follow her down her self-isolating path and call her out on her bullshit. She smiled at all of her. All of them. The fights, the pranks, the laughter and the crying.

All at once, Adora knew exactly what she wanted.

Adora leaned down slowly, a single blue eye opening with a questioning *mrrp?* Catra smiled as she realized Adora's trajectory. Their lips met softly, carefully, like dew droplets holding on to a blade of grass. Time stopped, and for a moment, so did Adora's worries.

She didn't know what the future held, wasn't sure she ever would. It was a whole new world out there, and she needed to learn the rules on how to play it. But right here, right now, she knew what she wanted.

And somehow, that felt like enough.

End Notes

First of all thank you so much to S00tspritezz for letting me use the panels they colored from the comic for this fic! Her art is freaking awesome, please go check them out!

The full comic is here!

Man this comic fucked me up the first time I read it. After our collective insanity over at the Flex died down, I was left feeling hollow but I didn't initially understand why. Until I realized what it was really depicting among the cute and cozy panels: Adora's PTSD. And it's realistic, and very on-brand with the series and how it handles mental health. But I guess it just broke my heart to see this poor girl struggling after her "happy ever after" and it made me think of my depression spirals when there is seemingly nothing "wrong" in my life, and how fucking frustrating it all feels. How you want to hide because you feel so embarrassed and humiliated at feeling that way when you are "supposed" to feel happy. Coincidentally, as I got back into my WIP for this fic, I got into one of those spirals, so writing this just felt very cathartic. We all need a Catra to keep us accountable for our bad coping mechanisms sometimes.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!